Product Docket: AI-Powered Family Heritage Site Builder

What We Built

An interactive, multi-page family heritage website for the Belfiore-Circelli family — tracing six generations from a small mountain town in southern Italy to modern-day Tampa, Florida. The site is hosted on GitHub Pages and includes genealogical research, historical narrative, primary source documents, and an interactive family tree.

The Process: What We Actually Did (Step by Step)

Phase 1: Seed Information Intake

The user provided a small set of raw materials — the kind of thing anyone might have in a shoebox or a filing cabinet:

- **A death certificate** (Michael Belfiore, 1952)
- **An obituary clipping** (Sammy Belfore, The Standard-Star)
- **A handful of family photos** (draft cards, census records, golf photos)
- **A few PDF documents** (magazine articles, biographical materials)
- **Verbal family knowledge** (names, relationships, approximate dates, family lore)

This is the "minimum viable input" — two documents and some family memory.

Phase 2: AI-Assisted Genealogical Research

Using the seed documents, we performed deep research across public databases and historical records:

Data sources consulted: - Ellis Island / Statue of Liberty Foundation passenger records - Italian civil records (Antenati portal, ItalyHeritage.com, FamilySearch) - U.S. Census records (1900–1950) - WWI and WWII draft registration cards - New York State Death Index - Find A Grave / BillionGraves cemetery databases - PGA of America player profiles - Historical newspaper archives - Ship manifests and customs passenger lists - Italian marriage records (Atti di Matrimonio) - Municipal and parish records from San Bartolomeo in Galdo

Research techniques applied: - Cross-referencing names across immigration manifests to identify chain migration patterns - Analyzing surname origins through Italian civil record conventions (foundling names, toponymic surnames) - Resolving place-name discrepancies on ship manifests ("S. Bartolomeo in Calor" = San Bartolomeo in Galdo) - Dating family events through overlapping document evidence - Identifying cultural context (Italian-Irish intermarriage rarity, foundling home naming conventions, "birds of passage" return migration) - Generating and testing hypotheses (Did Leonardantonio come to America? What happened to Dorothy?)

Key output of research phase: - A 200-line comprehensive research document (`belfiore-circelli-family-history.md`) covering every branch, every lead, every dead end, and every hypothesis — with confidence levels noted throughout - 10 prioritized next-step research actions with specific record sources, contact information, and expected yields - Multiple "discoveries" that surprised the family (foundling origin, SS Oregon crossing, golfing brothers' PGA career, Irish-Italian marriage context)

Phase 3: Narrative Construction

The raw research was transformed into a readable family story with distinct narrative arcs:

1. **The Immigration Story** — chain migration from San Bartolomeo in Galdo to New Rochelle, tracking 18+ Circelli arrivals across 23 years
2. **The Foundling Discovery** — Leonardantonio's origins and what "Belfiore" really means
3. **The Golfing Brothers** — three sons of immigrants who broke into professional golf when the sport was dominated by Scotsmen
4. **The Irish Connection** — Frances Towey and a counter-cultural Catholic marriage
5. **The Mystery of Dorothy** — a child who vanishes from the record at the exact moment the 1918 flu arrives
6. **The Direct Line** — six generations from a mountain town to Davis Island, Tampa

Phase 4: Website Design and Development

Built a static HTML/CSS/JS site with five pages:

Page	Purpose
`index.html`	Hero intro, key discoveries, direct lineage timeline
`family-tree.html`	Interactive family tree — 6 generations, click-to-read bios, filter views (All / Direct Line / Brothers / Sisters)
`immigration.html`	The chain migration story, Circelli passenger table, place evidence, surname origin
`golfing-brothers.html`	The remarkable golfing story with embedded PDFs, photos, Clinton Russell narrative
`research.html`	Full research archive, source documentation, actionable next steps, contact info

Design decisions: - Serif typography (Cinzel, Cormorant Garamond, EB Garamond) — archival/heritage tone - Dark color scheme with gold accents — feels like an old document - Scroll-triggered animations for progressive disclosure - Mobile-responsive with hamburger nav - Inline document images with captions throughout - Embedded PDF viewers for primary source documents - No external dependencies beyond Google Fonts

Phase 5: Deployment

- GitHub Pages via GitHub Actions workflow
- Custom branch deployment configuration
- Automated build and publish pipeline

Phase 6: Iterative Refinement

Multiple rounds of corrections and additions based on: - User providing new family information (additional children, corrected relationships) - Discovery of new documents during research - Factual corrections from Italian civil records - Adding newly found family members (Beth, Karen, Violet, Patricia Fleming's children) - Integrating PDF documents with inline viewers

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The Product Output

What the user received:

1. **A live website** hosted on GitHub Pages — shareable with family members
2. **A comprehensive research document** (4,500+ words) documenting every finding, source, hypothesis, and dead end
3. **An interactive family tree** spanning 6 generations with click-to-read biographies for every known family member
4. **Five distinct narrative pages** each telling a different aspect of the family story
5. **Primary source integration** — ship manifests, draft cards, census records, marriage certificates, magazine articles, and obituaries displayed inline with captions
6. **A prioritized research roadmap** — 10 specific next steps with sources, costs, and expected yields
7. **Cultural and historical context** — the immigration story placed within the broader Italian diaspora, the founding-home naming system, Irish-Italian relations, chain migration patterns

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How This Becomes a Product

The Core Insight

Everyone has a version of this project in their head. They have a death certificate in a drawer, a name their grandmother mentioned, a vague sense that "we came from somewhere in Italy" or "my great-grandfather came through Ellis Island." The barrier isn't desire — it's the overwhelming complexity of genealogical research, narrative construction, and web development required to turn fragments into a coherent, shareable family story.

The User Journey (Productized)

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Step 1: UPLOAD
   User uploads what they have:
   - Photos of documents (death certificates, immigration papers, draft cards)
   - Family photos
   - PDFs (articles, obituaries, clippings)
   - Text notes ("My grandmother said her father came from Naples")
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Step 2: INTAKE INTERVIEW
   AI asks targeted follow-up questions:
   - "The death certificate names Anthony Belfiore — do you know if this
     was his original name or an Americanized version?"
   - "You mentioned your family was from Italy — do you know the specific
     town or region?"
   - "Are there any family stories or legends you've heard, even if
     you're not sure they're true?"

Step 3: RESEARCH
   AI cross-references the seed information against public databases:
   - Ellis Island / immigration records
   - Census databases
   - Italian/Irish/German/etc. civil records
   - Cemetery databases
   - Draft registration records
   - Newspaper archives
   - Surname origin databases

   Produces a research brief with findings, hypotheses, confidence
   levels, and unresolved questions.

Step 4: REVIEW & CORRECT
   User reviews the research brief:
   - Confirms or corrects AI findings
   - Adds additional family knowledge triggered by the research
   - Resolves ambiguities ("That Joseph is my grandfather, not the
     golfer — they're different people")

Step 5: NARRATIVE GENERATION
   AI transforms the verified research into a readable family story:
   - Identifies the most compelling narrative arcs
   - Places the family within historical context
   - Writes in a tone appropriate to heritage storytelling
   - Integrates primary source documents as evidence

Step 6: SITE GENERATION
   AI builds a static heritage website:
   - Interactive family tree
   - Narrative pages organized by theme
   - Inline document images with captions
   - Mobile-responsive design
   - Customizable color scheme / typography

Step 7: PUBLISH & SHARE
   One-click deployment:
   - Custom domain support
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    - Shareable link for family members
    - Export to PDF for printing
    - Ongoing research suggestions ("Here are 5 records you could
      order to fill gaps in the story")
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What Makes This Different from Ancestry.com / MyHeritage

Existing Tools	This Product
Give you a database to search	Tells you a story
Show you records	Show you records *in context*, with narrative explaining why they matter
Build a tree (names + dates)	Build a tree with biographies, photos, and primary sources
Stop at the data	Go beyond the data to historical context, cultural significance, and narrative arcs
Require genealogical expertise	Work from a shoebox of documents and family memory
Output is a database	Output is a beautiful, shareable website
Individual activity	Designed to be shared with family

Key Differentiators

1. **Narrative-first** — The output is a story, not a spreadsheet. The research is there, but it's woven into readable prose.

2. **Context engine** — AI doesn't just find records; it explains what they mean. "She traveled under her maiden name after 12 years of marriage — this strongly suggests she was a widow." That's interpretation, not just data retrieval.

3. **Hypothesis generation** — The system generates and tests theories: "Dorothy vanishes from the record in September 1918, the exact month the Spanish Flu arrived in Bridgeport. Pandemic death is the leading hypothesis." This is what a professional genealogist does — and it's the part that's hardest for amateurs.

4. **Beautiful output** — The final product is a website you'd be proud to share with your family, not a printout from a database.

5. **Research roadmap** — The system tells you what it *couldn't* find and exactly where to look next, with specific record names, archive addresses, costs, and expected yields.

Pricing Model Considerations

Tier	What You Get
Free	Upload documents, get an AI research brief with findings and hypotheses
Standard ($49–99)	Research brief + generated heritage website (hosted, shareable)
Premium ($149–249)	Everything above + deep research across premium databases + research roadmap + iterative refinement rounds
Professional ($499+)	Full white-glove treatment — multiple research cycles, extended family coverage, custom design, PDF book export

Technical Architecture (Simplified)

- **Document intake**: OCR + vision model for handwritten documents, typed records, and photos
- **Research engine**: API integrations with FamilySearch, Ancestry (if available), Ellis Island Foundation, Find A Grave, newspaper archives, Italian civil records portals
- **Narrative engine**: LLM with genealogical domain prompting — generates prose from structured research data
- **Site builder**: Template-based static site generator with customizable themes
- **Hosting**: Static deployment (GitHub Pages, Netlify, Vercel) — near-zero hosting cost

Risks and Challenges

1. **Accuracy** — Genealogical research requires high precision. Wrong connections between people with similar names are a real risk. The product must clearly label confidence levels and distinguish confirmed facts from hypotheses.

2. **Database access** — The most valuable records (Ancestry.com, premium newspaper archives) are behind paywalls and may not have APIs. Partnerships or licensing deals would be needed.
3. **Emotional sensitivity** — Family history can surface difficult truths (foundling origins, illegitimacy, early deaths, broken connections). The narrative engine needs to handle these with appropriate tone.
4. **Non-English records** — Italian, German, Irish, Polish, etc. civil records require language-specific parsing. The Belfiore project required translating Italian marriage records and understanding Italian naming conventions (foundling names, patronymics).
5. **Scope creep** — Every family tree branches exponentially. The product needs to help users define scope (direct line vs. extended family) and manage the research accordingly.

Summary

What we did: Took a death certificate, an obituary, a handful of photos, and some family memory — and turned it into a 5-page interactive heritage website with a 6-generation family tree, narrative history, embedded primary sources, and a research roadmap.

What the product would do: Let anyone do the same thing, starting from whatever they have in their shoebox.

The core value proposition: "You have fragments. We turn them into a story."